MONTHLY UPDATE

Eswatini: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-16 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

> *Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.*

STATUS · PROGRESS · INSTITUTION HOSTING

GOVERNANCE
Legislation and regulation · Data protection · Regional collaboration

FINANCE
New investments

ICT INFRASTRUCTURE
Data Storage · Cybersecurity

DPI
Digital Identity and CRVS · Digital Payments and Fintech · Registries · Sectoral management information systems · Other GovTech and e-Gov

TECHNOLOGY
AI · ICT Industry · Innovation ecosystem

CAPACITY
Training and skills

INCLUSION
Digital divides

DATA
National statistics · Open data

Governance

Legislation and regulation

IMMIGRATION BILL TRAVELLER VETTING SYSTEM

- **New proposed law to screen foreigners entering country** — Times of Eswatini, 10 September 2026

  Eswatini's Immigration Bill would block entry by system-generated communication; about E6 million to implement.

Data protection

DATA PROTECTION AUTHORITY COMMUNITY OUTREACH CAMPAIGN

- **EDPA takes data protection services closer to Emaswati** — Eswatini Positive News, 17 September 2026

  Eswatini's Data Protection Authority is setting up information desks in major towns to give the public and businesses guidance on data-protection rights, responsibilities and registration. It began the outreach after finding that about eight in ten visitors to its trade fair stand had limited knowledge of the Data Protection Act.

Regional collaboration

COOPERATION TALKS WITH THE DIGITAL COOPERATION ORGANIZATION

- **Eswatini and DCO explore cooperation to accelerate digital transformation** — TechReview Africa, 3 September 2026

  DCO secretary-general meets Eswatini's ICT minister; 1.76m mobile connections against a 1.3m population, 95% 4G.

COMMUNICATIONS REGULATORS' MEMORANDUM WITH LESOTHO

- **Eswatini, Lesotho Join Forces to Tackle Cyber Threats** — Eswatini Positive News, 7 October 2026 LESOTHO

  Regulators' MoU of 3 Oct 2026: coordinated incident response, audits, training, joint research and information exchange.

Finance

New investments

DIGITAL ESWATINI PROJECT

- **EPTC seeks E455m loan for digital transformation** — Times of Eswatini, 10 September 2026

  Eswatini's posts and telecommunications corporation is seeking a US$26 million World Bank loan to finance the Digital Eswatini Project, under a bill tabled in Parliament. The bill would authorise the finance minister to issue a government guarantee of up to that amount for the loan.

- **E455m EPTC loan puts taxpayers on the line** — Independent News Eswatini, 21 September 2026

  Eswatini's House of Assembly took the second reading of three bills on 21 September 2026 financing the US$65 million World Bank Digital Eswatini Project. MPs focused on the US$26 million (about E455 million) loan to the state telecoms company EPTC, which the government would guarantee. The finance minister said that loan pays for EPTC's financial stabilisation and a change in its pension scheme, repayable from 2034 to 2051; the other two facilities fund broadband to Tinkhundla centres, schools and clinics, online government services, digital ID, payments and skills training. The bills now go to committee.

- **MPs BACK E1.14BN DIGITAL LOANS - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News, 21 September 2026

  Eswatini MPs spoke in support of the three World Bank facilities, together worth US$65 million (about E1.14 billion), that fund the Digital Eswatini Project, at the bills' second reading. The debate is summarised under the Eswatini Independent's report.

- **IDEA Half-Year Implementation Progress Report: January-June 2026 and Outlook for July-December 2026** — COMESA Secretariat (IDEA project), 1 October 2026 ANGOLA DRC MALAWI ZAMBIA EAST AFRICA SOUTHERN AFRICA

  COMESA spent 9% of USD 3.71m 2026 budget by June; Angola, DRC, Malawi, Zambia, Eswatini project status.

- **Who was held accountable for EPTC pension crisis?- Sen. Tony** — The Independent News Eswatini, 6 October 2026

> Eswatini senators asked on 5 October whether anyone had been held to account for the pension crisis at the state posts and telecommunications corporation, after Parliament approved the government guarantee for its US$26 million World Bank loan under the Digital Eswatini Project. The ICT minister said E26 million of the loan goes to the post office pension fund, affecting about 500 employees, and that the bank will manage and audit the loan.

ICT Infrastructure

Data Storage

> NATIONAL DATA CENTRE DISASTER RECOVERY SITE

- **Govt seeks to cancel E182m data recovery site loan** — Times of Eswatini, 22 September 2026

  Undrawn US$10.4m Exim Bank of India loan for Lubombo backup data site; project stalled, fees accruing, no reply yet.

- **Govt systems crippled by digital outages** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Eswatini's ICT ministry acknowledged outages across government online services, including elderly grants, e-Visa, road permits, scholarships, deeds registration and the IFMIS, without giving a cause. It did not confirm a reported breach at the Royal Science and Technology Park, home of the National Data Centre, or a reported EUR 1 million ransom demand.

- **E182m data centre loan not cancelled - Neal** — Times of Eswatini, 5 October 2026

  Eswatini's finance ministry says the E182 million India Exim Bank loan for a disaster recovery site at Siteki has not been cancelled. What the minister meant in Parliament was the commitment fee on the undrawn balance, which the lender has agreed to stop; 1% of the loan has been drawn.

> NATIONAL DATA CENTRE

- **Govt systems crippled by digital outages** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  RSTP confirms incident but not hack or ransom; at least 12 services down; outage first acknowledged 18 Sep 2026.

- **INTERPOL roped in on RSTP incident** — Times of Eswatini, 28 September 2026

  Eswatini's police have engaged INTERPOL over the incident at the National Data Centre and will investigate once a consultant hired by the science park and the ICT ministry reports. Unnamed sources suspect a third-party client gave attackers a way in; preliminary findings point to corrupted files and no data stolen.

Cybersecurity

> CYBERCRIME UNIT IN THE DIRECTORATE OF PUBLIC PROSECUTIONS

- **Minister Savannah launches cybersecurity awareness month** — Independent News Eswatini, 1 October 2026

  Eswatini's ICT minister launched National Cybersecurity Awareness Month and said a review of the National Cybersecurity Strategy has begun. The Director of Public Prosecutions said her office has set up a Cybercrime Unit and trained prosecutors on the 2022 cybercrime Act.

> NATIONAL CYBERSECURITY AWARENESS PROGRAMME

- **Minister Savannah launches cybersecurity awareness month** — Independent News Eswatini, 1 October 2026

  Summarised under Cybersecurity.

NATIONAL CYBERSECURITY STRATEGY REVIEW

- **Minister Savannah launches cybersecurity awareness month** — Independent News Eswatini, 1 October 2026

  Summarised under Cybersecurity.

NATIONAL CYBER DRILL

- **ESCCOM HOSTS INAUGURAL NATIONAL CYBER DRILL TO STRENGTHEN ESWATINI'S CYBER RESILIENCE** — The Bridge, 8 October 2026

  Eswatini held its first national cyber drill on 5 October: a multi-sector ransomware simulation for energy, telecoms, government, aviation, health and finance, facilitated by Lesotho's regulator. The communications commission showed a prototype incident-sharing platform.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

IDENTITY CARD AND PASSPORT PROCESSING AT HOME AFFAIRS

- **Network blackout strikes Home Affairs, EPTC** — Times of Eswatini, 16 September 2026

  A network outage on 16 September 2026 halted all identity card and passport processing at Eswatini's Home Affairs headquarters in Mbabane and at postal counters, with no restoration time given. Pupils needing original ID cards to sit examinations that week were among those turned away.

NATIONAL IDENTITY CARD

- **'Cat' Matlala wife arrest reignites Eswatini ID saga** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Civil Service Commission finds registrar unlawfully issued birth certificate and ID to a foreign national in Feb 2024.

Digital Payments and Fintech

UNAYO MOBILE BANKING PLATFORM

- **Standard Bank eyes integrated banking as Unayo phased out** — Eswatini Observer, 9 September 2026

  Unayo closes 31 December 2026; 200,000 retail and 5,000 business clients, only about 30% transacting.

- **STANDARD BANK REVIVES INSTANT MONEY AS UNAYO EXITS** — Eswatini Positive News, 4 October 2026

  SMS notice of Instant Money's return; no date, fees or limits yet; Unayo users told to withdraw before 31 Dec 2026.

ESWATINI PAYMENT SWITCH

- **Eswatini payment system enters new era** — Eswatini Observer, 21 September 2026

  The Central Bank of Eswatini says the fast-payments service of the Eswatini Payment Switch now links banks and mobile-money providers in real time at any hour, with QR-code payments to merchants being built next. Speaking at Tourism Nkwe 2026 in Mbabane, a deputy director said open banking and a domestic card switch will follow. Links to other countries come at a later stage.

- **DELTAPAY BRINGS INSTANT PAYMENTS CLOSER TO HOME** — Eswatini Positive News, 12 October 2026

> Wallet transfers in seconds, 24/7, to participating banks and wallets; follows full licence; go-live date not given.

> PROVIDENT FUND DIGITISATION
>
> - **ENPF cuts claims processing from days to three hours** — Times of Eswatini, 7 October 2026
>
> Three-hour payout pilot to E5,000 for KYC'd members; debit-card contributions via portal; 180,000 active members.

> POST OFFICES AS GOVERNMENT PAYMENT POINTS
>
> - **GOVT TO USE POST OFFICES AS COMMUNITY DIGITAL CENTRES – PS PRINCE MASHISHIMBA** — Eswatini Positive News, 9 October 2026
>
> Eswatini Post to join e-government for citizen authentication, document checks and payments; World Post Day 2026.

Registries

> NATIONAL POSTCODE AND ADDRESSING PROJECT
>
> - **Matsapha first to roll out addressing system in eight weeks** — Eswatini Positive News, 11 September 2026
>
> First municipality on the National Postcode and Addressing Project; street signs due inside eight weeks.

> VOTER REGISTER
>
> - **Biometric technology set to strengthen voter registration** — Eswatini Positive News, 11 September 2026
>
> Continuous Voter Registration with biometric capture, aimed at duplicate registration, ahead of 2028 polls.

> VOTER REGISTRATION
>
> - **IMBALI REGISTER TO VOTE AHEAD OF ELECTIONS AT MBANGWENI** — Eswatini Positive News, 12 September 2026
>
> EBC used Umhlanga 2026 to register young women to vote, ID card in hand, ahead of elections.

> SOCIAL REGISTRY (IMBELEKO)
>
> - **LUBOMBO MPs JOIN DPM TO MAKE EVERY VULNERABLE HOUSEHOLD COUNT - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News, 16 September 2026
>
> 216 collectors and 22 supervisors recruited; Lubombo household collection 2026-10-12 to 2026-11-27.

Sectoral management information systems

> INTEGRATED FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT INFORMATION SYSTEM
>
> - **Govt systems crippled by digital outages** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026
>
> Summarised under Data Storage.
>
> - **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026
>
> Summarised under Data Storage.
>
> - **System glitch stalls civil servants' loans** — Eswatini Observer, 5 October 2026
>
> Lenders locked out of IFMIS cannot check the 33% deduction threshold; new loans stalled, instalments still flowing.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

AUDITOR-GENERAL STRATEGIC PLAN 2026-2030

- **Auditors Embrace AI to Protect Public Funds** — Eswatini Positive News, 7 September 2026

  Eswatini's audit office hosted a week-long peer programme at which supreme audit institutions across the region weighed the use of artificial intelligence in government audit. No tool, pilot, audit methodology or procurement is named.

E-VISA PLATFORM

- **PM CALLS FOR DISRUPTION TO FIX TOURISM BOTTLENECKS - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News, 17 September 2026

  PM Dlamini concedes e-Visa delays and payment failures; Payment Switch to add open banking and card switching.

- **Govt systems crippled by digital outages** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

COMPANY REGISTRATION THROUGH THE GOVERNMENT PORTAL

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

GOVERNMENT IN YOUR HAND CITIZEN APPLICATION

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

Technology

AI

FISCALISATION AND ELECTRONIC INVOICING SYSTEM

- **BE backs ERS e-invoicing but demands practical rollout** — Independent News Eswatini, 7 September 2026

  Eswatini's national business body backed the revenue service's move to electronic invoicing while asking that it be made affordable and workable across existing technologies before national rollout.

- **Retail, wholesale sector steps up for e-invoicing pilot** — Times of Eswatini, 9 September 2026

  Business Eswatini convenes retail and wholesale members with ERS on the fiscalisation project ahead of implementation.

- **Three tech firms connect to ERS e-invoicing system** — Independent News Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Three providers, one a young local firm; accounting and POS systems must link to TaxCore to strengthen VAT.

NATIONAL AI STRATEGY

- **Eswatini seeks responsible AI use through national strategy** — Eswatini Positive News, 16 September 2026

> Eswatini has hired a consultant to draft a national AI strategy, the ICT minister's representative said at a COMESA regional validation meeting in Ezulwini on 16 September 2026.

ICT Industry

> BUY ESWATINI MARKET-ACCESS PLATFORM

- **Taiwan Opens Global Markets for Eswatini Through Buy Eswatini** — Eswatini Positive News, 5 September 2026

  Taiwan-funded platform handed to EIPA at EITF, 3 Sep 2026; Phase 3 scale-up funding still sought.

Innovation ecosystem

> SYMPOSIUM ON DIGITAL TOOLS FOR SMALL AND MEDIUM ENTERPRISES

- **Work Smarter: Embrace Technology, Cut Costs, Grow** — United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) Eswatini, 3 September 2026

  ~150 delegates at the UNDP CREATE symposium, Manzini, 2 Sept 2026, on cutting MSME costs with digital tools.

> FINTECH FORUM ESWATINI

- **FINTECH WORKING GROUP BECOMES FINTECH FORUM ESWATINI** — Eswatini Positive News, 23 September 2026

  CBE governor widens the group to academia, industry, innovators and students; MoU to formalise the forum to follow.

Capacity

Training and skills

> DIGITAL SKILLS WORKSHOP SERIES AT THE NATIONAL TRADE FAIR

- **DIGITAL SKILLS OPEN NEW OPPORTUNITIES FOR ESWATINI'S FUTURE - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News - News Website, 2 September 2026

  Ministry of ICT runs a digital-skills workshop series at the 58th Eswatini International Trade Fair.

> SCHOOL ICT EQUIPMENT DONATION

- **Technology devices take schools into digital era – Handsome** — Independent News Eswatini, 15 September 2026

  Taiwan donates 1,140 computers to 49 Eswatini schools; 40 interactive screens; US$4.75m education grant.

> DIGITAL ESWATINI CHANGE AGENTS

- **E1.06BN DIGITAL ESWATINI PUTS PEOPLE BEFORE TECHNOLOGY** — Eswatini Positive News, 24 September 2026

  About 40 change agents from five ministries and parastatals held a change-readiness workshop in Mbabane on 24 September, assessing their own directorates ahead of implementation of the World Bank-financed Digital Eswatini Project (US$65 million, about E1.06 billion). They are to help public servants adjust to the new digital systems.

Inclusion

Digital divides

SMART AFRICA GENDER IMPACT ASSESSMENT TOOLS FOR DIGITAL POLICY

- **SMART AFRICA TO TEST GENDER IMPACT TOOLS IN ESWATINI** — Eswatini Positive News, 5 October 2026

  Three tools validated at the ICT ministry ahead of a 6-8 Oct 2026 Mbabane co-creation and piloting workshop.

- **Gender checks proposed for digital policies** — Times of Eswatini, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

  Eswatini's ICT minister, opening the gender impact assessment workshop in Mbabane, said the government wants such assessments built into digital policies and programmes before they are implemented.

- **Gender impact tool targets the digital divide facing women** — FinGuard Magazine, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

  A magazine account of the same Eswatini pilot of Smart Africa's gender impact assessment framework, which is meant to test whether digital programmes narrow the divide facing women. It names the tools differently from the ministry's account.

- **Minister Savannah vows to continue advocating for women In tech** — Independent News Eswatini, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

  Eswatini's ICT ministry and Smart Africa opened a workshop on 7 October to develop and pilot gender impact assessment tools for digital policy, with Eswatini and The Gambia as pilot countries. Three instruments are to be tested on selected digital policies before validation.

Data

National statistics

FINSCOPE CONSUMER SURVEY

- **Eswatini targets 100% financial inclusion through FinScope survey** — Eswatini Positive News, 10 September 2026

  3,200 households in 320 enumeration areas; first inclusion read since 2018's 87%.

Open data

INVESTMENT ATTRACTIVENESS AND MARKET INTELLIGENCE DASHBOARDS

- **NEW TRADE DASHBOARDS OPEN GLOBAL MARKETS FOR ESWATINI - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News, 18 September 2026

  Eswatini launched two public dashboards, one on investment attractiveness and one on export-market intelligence, built by the trade ministry and the investment promotion authority with the International Trade Centre under EU support. No data licence or update schedule is stated.

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